

AETHER WIRELESS · KNOWLEDGE BASE

Device Upgrade Guidelines

Category B — Policy & Process Knowledge Base

Document ID	AW-DEV-001
Version	2.0
Last Updated	August 2026
Department	Device Finance
Company	Aether Wireless
Classification	Internal — Training & Reference

Overview

This document outlines the policies and procedures for upgrading mobile devices on the Aether Wireless network. It covers eligibility requirements, financing limits by credit tier, early-upgrade options, available devices with pricing, APR qualifications, trade-in values, and the step-by-step upgrade process. All staff must follow these guidelines when assisting customers with device upgrades.

Eligibility Requirements

To qualify for a device upgrade, the account and device must meet the following criteria:

- **Device Tenure:** The current device must have been active on the account for at least 12 months, OR the device must have reached 50% of its installment term (whichever comes first).
- **Payment Status:** The account must have no more than **2 unpaid installments** at the time of upgrade.
- **Account Status:** The account must be in **Active** standing. Suspended or terminated accounts are not eligible for upgrades.
- **Credit Approval:** The customer must be approved for the financing limit associated with their credit tier.

Device Financing Limits by Credit Tier

Customers are assigned a credit tier at account opening based on their creditworthiness. This tier determines how many devices they can finance simultaneously and the total financing amount.

Credit Tier	Rating Description	Maximum Devices	Total Financing Limit
Tier A	Excellent	4	\$200
Tier B	Good	3	\$150
Tier C	Fair	2	\$100

Tier C Down Payment Requirement

Customers on **Tier C** must pay a **down payment of 20%** on any new device at the time of upgrade. This amount is applied to the total device price before financing.

Early Upgrade Options

Customers who wish to upgrade before completing their installment term have the following options:

Scenario	Upgrade Option
Device owned 12+ months	Standard trade-in; apply current device value to new device
Device has accidental damage	File a protection claim; use claim payout toward new device
Device lost or stolen	File a protection claim; use payout toward new device
Device owned less than 12 months	Pay remaining installment balance in full before upgrading

Available Devices and Installment Pricing

All devices below are available with 24-month installment plans. Monthly payment amounts are calculated based on 24-month financing.

Device	Full Retail Price	24-Mo. Monthly Payment
iPhone 16	\$899	\$37.46
iPhone 16 Pro	\$1,199	\$49.96
Galaxy S25	\$899	\$37.46
Galaxy S25 Ultra	\$1,299	\$54.12
Pixel 9	\$799	\$33.29
Pixel 9 Pro	\$999	\$41.63
OnePlus 12	\$699	\$29.13
Edge 50	\$599	\$24.96

APR Qualifications

The Annual Percentage Rate (APR) applied to device financing depends on the customer's rate plan:

Rate Plan	APR
Premium	0%
Unlimited	0%
Business	0%
Essential	6.99%
Standard	6.99%

Customers on Essential or Standard plans who wish to qualify for 0% APR must upgrade to Premium or Unlimited at the time of device upgrade.

Trade-In Value Ranges

When a customer trades in their current device as part of an upgrade, the trade-in credit is calculated based on the device category and condition. Values are expressed as a percentage of the device's original retail price.

Device Category	Trade-In Value Range
Flagship (iPhone 15 Pro, Galaxy S24, Pixel 8 Pro)	40% – 60%
Mid-Range (iPhone 15, Galaxy A55, Pixel 8a)	25% – 40%
Budget (iPhone SE, Galaxy A15, Moto G)	15% – 25%
Damaged (screen crack, water damage, functional issues)	10% – 30%

Trade-in values are determined at the time of upgrade based on a physical or diagnostic assessment. Damaged devices receive a lower value depending on the severity of damage.

Step-by-Step Upgrade Process

Follow these eight steps when processing a device upgrade:

- 1. Verify Account Standing** – Confirm the account is Active and has no more than 2 unpaid installments.
- 2. Confirm Device Eligibility** – Ensure the current device has been on the account for 12+ months or has reached 50% of the installment term.
- 3. Check Credit Tier** – Review the customer's credit tier to confirm financing limits and down payment requirements.
- 4. Select New Device** – Help the customer choose from available devices. Calculate the monthly payment based on their rate plan APR.
- 5. Process Trade-In (if applicable)** – Assess the current device. Apply the trade-in credit to reduce the new device price or total financing amount.
- 6. Calculate Final Terms** – Determine the down payment (Tier C only), monthly payment, total cost, and remaining balance if trading in early.
- 7. Complete the Upgrade** – Submit the upgrade request. Confirm the new device shipment or schedule in-store pickup.
- 8. Transfer Protection (if applicable)** – If the customer has device protection, initiate a coverage transfer to the new device with no gap in coverage.

Device Protection Transfer

When a customer upgrades to a new device, their existing device protection plan must be transferred to the replacement device. The transfer process ensures:

- **No Coverage Gap** – Protection remains active from the moment the old device is deactivated.
- **Same Deductible** – The deductible amount carries over to the new device.
- **Prorated Credit** – Any unused portion of the existing protection plan is applied to the new plan.

Staff must process the protection transfer during the upgrade transaction to avoid lapses in coverage.

Promo Credit Forfeiture

Aether Wireless occasionally offers promotional credits toward devices, such as bill credits spread over 24 months. If a customer pays off their device balance early (before the 24-month term ends), **any remaining promotional credits are forfeited.**

Example: A customer receives \$400 in bill credits over 24 months (\$16.67/month). If they pay off the device at month 12, they will have received only \$200 in credits. The remaining \$200 in promotional credits is canceled.

Staff must inform customers of this policy before processing any early payoff.

FAQs

Q: Can I upgrade if I have 3 unpaid installments?

A: No. Customers must have no more than 2 unpaid installments to qualify for an upgrade. Bring your account current before proceeding.

Q: My device is only 8 months old. Can I still upgrade?

A: You may upgrade if the device has reached 50% of its installment term. For a 24-month plan, that means 12 months. If your term is shorter, check with a representative to confirm eligibility.

Q: How much down payment do Tier C customers need?

A: Tier C customers must pay 20% of the device price as a down payment at the time of upgrade.

Q: What happens to my promotional credits if I pay off my device early?

A: Any remaining promotional credits will be forfeited. You will lose the unbilled portion of any bill credits tied to the device.

Q: Can I transfer my device protection to my new phone?

A: Yes. Protection transfers with no coverage gap. The existing deductible applies to the new device, and any unused protection fees are credited to the new plan.

Q: How is my trade-in value determined?

A: Trade-in value is based on the device category and condition. Flagship devices in good condition receive 40-60% of retail value, while damaged devices receive 10-30% depending on damage severity.

For additional assistance with device upgrades, contact Device Finance at 1-800-AETHER-1 or visit your local Aether Wireless store.